dominant bottom hand, which led to his working the ball across the line to the leg side with a twist of the wrist. At the highest level, this is seen as an exploitable flaw.

Another coach, a different set of selectors, could have come to a contrasting decision, and trusted a natural talent. Conversely, James could have been promoted prematurely and been found out. Ultimately, after about three years on the fringe, he was given his chance, and excelled in seven Test matches before, at the age of twenty-six, fate intervened.

He was forced to retire after being diagnosed with a serious but rare congenital heart condition known as arrhythmogenic right ventricular cardiomyopathy (ARVC), which can be fatal during vigorous exercise. He described the sensation of having his heart shocked back into a normal rhythm by an implanted defibrillator as like being hit by a ball delivered at 100 mph.

He has since been appointed as a full-time independent England selector, so he will understand the onerous nature of the process. I've been in selection meetings, judging batsmen with as much objectivity as I can, when the sense of responsibility has been almost overpowering. Decisions are hard, sometimes horrible, and often final.

It is sometimes easier to judge a bowler than a batsman; that's why they seem to have fewer games in which to prove themselves. If they bowl thirty overs in each innings, across three or four Tests, you get a fair idea of the parameters of their potential. A batsman, in the same time frame, can get out unluckily to two or three very good deliveries. The temptation is always to offer another chance.

Whether that's deserved is open to judgement. As captain I've been in selection meetings where we're not exactly ending a bloke's career, but we are giving it a big old dent. I know what a struggling player is going through, the fears and frustrations he is trying to contain, because I have been there myself.